

CLASS 1 HANDOUT



Safe People & Feelings

Finding Peace Within

Safe People Are

- People who react to you in a different way than those who injured you. Use your memory to tell the difference.
- People, who, over time, have a loving track record. See if their walk matches their talk.
- People who can be observed from some emotional distance. Take small risks in vulnerability before taking bigger risks.
- People with the ability to accept imperfections in others. This refers to the difference between those who love the outside and those who love the inner self.
- People who are no stranger to pain, yet are recovering. Those who have suffered spiritually and emotionally can identify with developmental injuries.
- People who are aware of their own deficits. Those who know their unfinished parts are more likely to be safe with the unfinished parts of others.
- People who have truth without condemnation. It's easier to entrust our weaknesses to those who love us, and who will speak the truth in love
- People who have grace without license. Attaching to others who see grace as leading to greater responsibility helps us to experience grace appropriately.
- People who bring out your best in life. Ask yourself if your relationship with this person has made you more or less loving and responsible.

Break the dysfunctional family rules of "don't talk, don't trust, don't feel", by actively seeking a confessional relationship. Generally, a "safe" person will give you permission (when you can't give it to yourself) to be human. Safety is measured by our ability to be who we really are with a particular person or in a certain setting - a place where we can talk about our fears, our feelings, our experiences without being judged or shamed.

There are safe people and safe places. To find them you must take a risk. Share; check; share. We are created not to be dependent or independent, but interdependent. Don't expect perfection from yourself or from others, but look for a realistic "good enough."

Whatever is unconfessed is beyond the reach of healing. The isolated injury that stays hidden feels "bad." The injury that is connected feels loved.

From *Hiding From Love* by Dr. John Townsend

Exercise: Safe people check

Think of 2–3 people in your life. Write their names at the top, then check the traits each one shows. Use the last column for yourself.

Safe people are...	-----	-----	-----	Me
Reacts to me differently than those who hurt me				
Has a loving track record over time				
Can be observed from some emotional distance				
Accepts imperfections in others				
Knows pain, and is recovering				
Is aware of their own deficits				
Has truth without condemnation				
Has grace without license				
Brings out my best				

1. Which of these traits do I show to others?

2. Who in my life feels safest, and why?

Color Code - Blue

Strengths

As an individual

- Sees life as a serious endeavor
- Sincere and emotionally deep
- Analytically oriented
- High achiever

Limitations

As an individual

- Highly emotional
- Smug and self-righteous
- Controlling and/or envious of others' success when too easily obtained
- Strong perfecting and performance orientation

Color Code - Red

Strengths

As an individual

- Excels with logical thinking
- Committed to a productive lifestyle
- Dynamic and direct
- Thrives on independence
- Natural leader
- Highly resourceful (strong survivor)
- Creative in crisis

Limitations

As an individual

- Promotes turmoil and conflict when a personal goal is to be gained
- Rationalizes and denies own failings
- Always right
- Often arrogant and defiant of authority
- Inpatient with others

Color Code - White

Strengths

As an individual

- Quiet, reflective, and peaceful
- Sincere and genuine lifestyle
- Patient with others
- Blends into all situations

Limitations

As an individual

- Unresponsive or not openly excited about experiences
- Has problems becoming intimate
- Bashful and unsure of self
- Often lazy and unwilling to take responsibility to self
- Resists making commitments

Color Code - Yellow

Strengths

As an individual

- Highly optimistic (rarely depressed)
- Likes self and accepts others easily
- Loves to volunteer for opportunities
- Sees life as an experience to be enjoyed
- Adventurous and daring

Limitations

As an individual

- Needs to look good socially (high priority)
- Irresponsible and unreliable
- Self-centered and egotistical
- Superficial and mostly interested in a good time
- Exaggerates successes and omits unpleasant truths
- Unable to confront or face issues

Feelings

What generates them?

From *Facing Codependence* by Pia Mellody, Andrea Miller, & J. Keith Miller

- The four areas of **REALITY**
 - **BODY:**
 - Our five senses bring input from outer world to our inner world
 - **THINKING:**
 - We interpret, draw conclusions, and give meaning to the sensory input
 - **FEELING:**
 - Physiological response to our thoughts (also called emotions)
 - Uses up energy in our body
 - **BEHAVIOR:**
 - What we choose to do (or not do) as a result of our feelings
- Our belief system (based on our history and values) affects the way we think, feel, and behave
- How we process our thoughts impacts where our feelings go (positive or negative) & intensity of them
 - What we feel is what we feel
 - We cannot change our feelings
 - We can change our thoughts
- We learn to acknowledge it so we can process it
 - Denied feelings are a trigger for inappropriate behavior
 - Unprocessed feelings are stored in our bodies, they don't just disappear because we choose not to process them

Tools for Feelings

- Allow yourself to feel them
 - Let them be as big (or little) and overwhelming/confusing (ugly) as they really are
- Find the truth
 - What/who is the source (external or internal)?
 - Is there an event that triggered it?
 - Use the True – Not True – Questionable Tool to separate the feelings from the thoughts
- Talk them out with a safe person
- Purge them
 - Journal? Art?
 - Physical: clean the house, beat up a pillow, break dishes, throw darts at a picture
 - Express them in a way that does not harm you, others, or valuable property

Automatic Negative Thoughts

from *Change Your Brain Change Your Life* by Daniel Amen

- Negative thoughts invade your mind like ants at a picnic
 - When you notice an ANT enter your mind, acknowledge it and talk back to it
 - When you hear yourself talk use an ANT, stop and correct yourself
- All or Nothing
 - Everything is all good or all bad; same as black and white thinking
 - One event/moment doesn't define the entirety
- Always Thinking
 - Overgeneralize: using words like "always" or "never"
 - Helplessness that you do not have control over your behavior/self
- Focusing on the Negative
 - Only see the negative aspect of a situation regardless of the positives
 - Hopelessness or wanting to "give up"
- Thinking with your Feelings
 - Assuming our feeling is correct versus questioning it; feelings can lie
 - Use the True – Not True – Questionable Tool
- Guilt Beating
 - Using guilt to control our behavior or using negative control on others
 - When we feel pushed to do something, our natural tendency is to push back
- Labeling
 - Calling yourself (or another) a negative term or name
 - Worthlessness, helplessness, and hopelessness; giving up before trying
- Fortune-Telling (**RED ANT**)
 - Predicting the worse even though you don't know what will happen
- Mind Reading (**RED ANT**)
 - Assuming you know what another is thinking
- Blame (**RED ANT**)
 - Blaming others and not taking responsibility for ourselves
 - Powerless to change our own behavior

Feelings Chart

From **Facing Codependence** by Pia Mellody, Andrea Miller, & J. Keith Miller

Feeling (Reality)	Gift (Our Feelings)	Challenge (Induced or Carried Feelings)
Joy	Hope / Peace	
Pain	Change / Healing	Hopelessness / Depression
Anger	Energy / Power	Rage / Devalue
Fear	Protection / Wisdom	Panic / Paranoia / Helplessness
Guilt	Values / Integrity	False Guilt / Prolonged Guilt
Shame	Accountability / Fallibility (Limits)	Carried Shame / Shame Bound

Pain

from **The Language of Letting Go** by Melody Beattie

- Many sources of pain: history, current events, transitions or “life events”
- Our choice to
 - Let pain lead and guide us to a positive outcome (healthy choices/behaviors)
 - Stop or avoid pain (addictions, focus on others, denial/repression)
- Takes courage to stay still and feel - it will only hurt for awhile and then it will heal
- Can be confused with Anger

Anger

from **Good ‘n’ Angry: How to Handle Your Anger Positively** by Les Carter

- Three general ways people handle anger
- Repressed (denial)
 - If I ignore it, it will go away
 - Pushing from conscious to subconscious leads to it worsening
- Expressed (outwardly communicated)
 - Assertive: respects the dignity/value of another
 - Aggressive: without regard for other person’s worth/value
- Released (let it go)
 - Making the conscious decision that anger is no longer needed
 - Must first be able to assertively express anger
- Can be confused with Pain

Fear

from **Feel the Fear & Do It Anyway** by Susan Jeffers

- Fear is a part of life
 - Wings: It can be a companion on this journey of life and we take flight
 - Anchor: It can become an anchor and we become frozen (in fear)
- By confronting a situation or “doing something”
 - Fear gradually decreases
 - Self-confidence and self-worth increase
- Fear does not equal isolation
- Fearing fear is worse than facing fear (helplessness)

Guilt

from **Mind Over Emotions** by Les Carter

- Communicates that something is amiss in our thinking and behavior
- True Guilt
 - Inner voice to live a moral, responsible life
- False Guilt
 - Feeling of remorse that is judgmental toward oneself
 - Decreases value/self-worth and increases fear of being “found out” and punished
- Creates a sense of isolation
- Usually is accompanied by Shame

Shame

from **Letting Go of Shame** by Ronald and Patricia Potter-Efron

- Represents a person’s identity
- Defense mechanisms: denial, perfectionism, arrogance, exhibitionism, rage
- Become aware of your shame and examine it even though we want to hide from it
 - Where does your shame come from? (society, family, significant other, yourself)
- Shame heals when shared with another
- Set positive goals and take responsibility for reforming your thoughts and changing your behaviors
- Usually is accompanied by Guilt

Take-home: Catch an ANT

From *Change Your Brain Change Your Life* by Daniel Amen

Once a day this week, notice an automatic negative thought (ANT). Name its type, then talk back to it with a truer thought.

Types: all or nothing · always thinking · focusing on the negative · thinking with your feelings · guilt beating · labeling · fortune-telling · mind reading · blame

The ANT	Its type	A truer thought